THE SHE LIST



Sindhu Gangadharan, *47*

Senior vice-president & managing director, SAP Labs India

SELVAPRAKASH LAKSHMANAN

Soft Power

AROUND THE TIME SINDHU Gangadharan decided to attend engineering college, her father suggested that she pursue medicine instead. "I was like 'no, I need to go into technology'. That was very clear." By the late 1990s when she graduated in computer science, the software boom was evident in Bengaluru, her hometown. "And you knew that being in tech was cool and you could do a lot of things. It was very clearly fascinating," she says.

In 1999, she joined SAP which had set up an R&D centre in Bengaluru the year before. Soon after that, she moved to Walldorf, where the German tech giant is headquartered, for an 18-year stint. In late 2019, she returned as managing director of SAP Labs India which, at a headcount of 12,800 across five cities, accounts for 40 per cent of the company's global R&D staff. India, she says, is the only location that spans the entire breadth of SAP's product portfolio.

A topper in school and college, Sindhu says she has been a hard worker all through. "I find joy in my work. I wouldn't call myself a workaholic, honestly," she says. "I always get asked the question 'what is your mantra?' Hard work, discipline and not giving up." Sindhu's approach is simple. "How does it matter if you are a woman or a man? You know your stuff, you do your stuff, that's what matters." She recounts a life lesson learnt early in her career when a mentor gave her some cautionary advice about work-life balance. "The last thing I expected the mentor to tell me was about work-life balance instead of 'go do it'," she says. "Hence, after that, I always advise people to make sure you talk to multiple people and then decide for yourself."

ACCOMPLISHMENT

One of the early recruits, she now leads SAP Labs India, the German tech behemoth's largest R&D centre globally

Currently, Sindhu is also vice-chairperson of software industry body Nasscom.

Among Sindhu's formative experiences was being a Scouts and Guides leader in school—it meant doing a lot of things on her own, like putting up a tent or cooking her own food. The latter, she greatly enjoys. "I bake a lot. So, Sundays are when I try to hang around in the kitchen." Her baking is also something her colleagues at the Monday morning meetings at the office look forward to. Some good food for thought! ■

–Ajay Sukumaran

FIRST OFF THE BLOCK

"Don't give up. Don't set boundaries. Just go for it"

FAVOURITE HOLIDAY

Sindhu and her husband like to go to places off the beaten track and try out unusual activities